

also recognize that players might take events in a different direction than originally anticipated. A game with little free will isn't really a game so much as a Storyteller monologue, after all, and while it's certainly acceptable to nudge players now and then, keeping them tied down to a single path through a predetermined story goes against the intention of **Changeling: The Dreaming**.

Character Driven

In a character-driven chronicle, the players create their characters first — and collaborate with the Storyteller on building a setting — and then the Storyteller designs stories around those characters. The results can be quite an interesting mix of characters that wouldn't necessarily seem to have much in common to start, but like the unlikely heroes of countless stories, wind up facing hardships and coming together...or tearing apart.

One big advantage of a character-driven game is the fact that players are engaged from the very beginning, simply because these are the characters they are most interested in playing. The level of involvement in building the characters and the setting also makes for immediate engagement on the part of the players, as they have a strong hand in what the game is about right from the beginning. Of course, where characters start off and where they end up aren't always quite the same thing, but at least at the outset the players have a firm grasp of what to expect.

Character Creation

One of the most important, yet often overlooked, aspects of roleplaying is the character creation process itself; while everyone knows the rules and numbers involved, the social dimension of making characters should not be forgotten. After all, these characters are going to be the protagonists of a tale the group will be spending hours and hours exploring!

Group Character Creation

If at all possible, the group should create their characters together, ideally with the Storyteller on hand to answer questions and contribute input as needed. Regardless of whether the characters are completely finished or if the actual points and numbers are handled later, being able to hash out concepts and relationships and setting details with the rest of the group is a valuable creative experience. It allows for rapid feedback and easy forging of character ties, which in turn makes for a stronger group on the whole.

Making characters together is useful even if the characters will begin the game as strangers to each other, because the players are still able to make connections and suggestions even if such things won't come right away during play. Two characters might not know each other, but if the players talk and wind up building a common experience into their pasts, once the characters find out it will go a long way toward understanding why they might work together during the chronicle.

Of course, sometimes it's simply not possible for everyone in a group to sit around a table and make characters together. That's fine! However, it is still recommended that the Storyteller involve any absent players as best he can — sending emails, making calls, even setting up a video chat — so that those players don't feel left out of the process. Nobody wants to be the odd one out of a tightly-knit group, after all.

Embrace Flaws

One of the best pieces of advice for making interesting characters is to avoid trying to make perfect characters — those that have nothing to lose, never make mistakes, and excel at everything they do. It can be difficult to avoid thinking defensively, treating the story as the antagonist and building a character who can survive anything unscathed, but the rewards for resisting this urge are great indeed. While showing off exceptional ability certainly makes for fun stories, so does confronting vulnerabilities, as it forces characters to face situations where success is far from certain, and requires them to reach deep to face their worst fears.

This does not mean a character must be a dramatic fop or hopeless sad sack who's terrible at everything, or that a character must have a melodramatic personal life. Those can be fun, but that's not what it means to embrace flaws. It simply means giving a character a defining weakness or two, something that makes them vulnerable and interesting. This weakness doesn't have to be innate, either, though it certainly can be — a character could also be vulnerable to constant trouble at home, for instance. So long as it potentially poses a serious obstacle or threat, any sort of weakness will do.

For instance, a peerless swordswoman could have a chaotic family life, constantly requiring her to bail out her mortal siblings from one fix or another. What will she do when her lady requires her presence at a critical duel on the same day her little brother needs her to bail him out of jail after his latest brush with the law? Does she do her duty and get snubbed by her family, or lose her reputation but keep her siblings close? Her family is dragging her down, but they're her family — what does it say about her if she turns her back on them? Is there another way out, or will she have to accept giving up half of herself to please the other half?

Indeed, while a lot of character design focuses on strengths, it's good to think about the sort of mistakes a character makes. Does he have an actual tragic flaw such as consuming jealousy, or is he simply bad with money? Does he stretch himself too thin with too many commitments, and find himself canceling on or disappointing others as a result? Even apparently minor things like always running late or being too quick with a cutting remark can become memorable and even dramatic habits over the course of a story.

Try to avoid picking problems that aren't really problems — a character who is bad with money but lives mostly in the Dreaming and so rarely uses the stuff doesn't really have much of a problem. Likewise, a character who is supposedly a sucker for a pretty face but never pursues any attractive supporting characters isn't going to make any interesting mistakes as a